

Chapter 38-1: Embrace

As soon as her words fell, the cutting pain from the fierce wind on her face stopped abruptly, replaced by a gentle breeze like that in a forest. A corner of clothing slid past her nose, carrying a crisp, cold fragrance that covered the pervasive smell of blood.

The rabbit in her hands was still struggling. Ning Fuyi slowly opened her eyes to see blinding white light, which then became gentle. Light feathers drifted down from all directions, landing on the shoulders of the person before her.

Chu Qingqiu stood with her back to her, White Bone in her hand transformed into a white jade staff. As she swept out a gust of fierce wind, over ten Guijian Sect disciples around them all flew out, tumbling to the ground one after another. The black smoke and blood mist were also dispersed.

Ning Fuyi's breathing slowed down. She stared fixedly at Chu Qingqiu's back, somewhat dazed.

Calling out to Chu Qingqiu earlier had been an instinctive action. Only now did she have time to think - this One-Thought Pearl was given to her by Chu Qingqiu, so the Nightmare Beast must also be Chu Qingqiu's handiwork.

"Divine, Divine Venerable?" The Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate disciples who had been huddled on the ground raised their heads. While having escaped death, they were also very surprised.

"Get up quickly." Chu Qingqiu said coldly, then formed a flower shape with both hands in front of her chest. Thousands of silver threads shot out from her sleeves, drilling into the minds of the Guijian Sect disciples. The several people immediately let out heart-wrenching screams as black smoke emerged from their mouths and noses, gathering into a cluster that fled toward the dense forest.

But it was scattered by White Bone that suddenly flew out, disappearing without a trace.

Seeing the demonic qi dispersed, the other disciples also hurriedly got up from the ground. Still shaken, two Southern Garden disciples had suffered serious injuries and were frantically supported by their fellow disciples.

"Thank you for saving us, Divine Venerable..." Hong Ying dragged his heavy sword, saying with lingering fear. "Why would the demonic clan break into the Chaotic Realm! I must notify those outside, or more disciples will suffer."

With that, he took off the sound transmission plaque from his waist. However, the jade plaque that should have been glowing with spiritual light was now completely dim. No matter how he shook it, it couldn't transmit any sound.

"Why is this happening!" Hong Ying was immediately stunned.

"What else could it be? The Chaotic Realm has been destroyed." Ning Fuyi, who had been standing at the back, suddenly spoke up. She tossed the rabbit back into her One-Thought Pearl and wiped off the blood mist that had somehow splattered on her face.

Hong Ying looked at her in surprise.

"Why did these demons come here? Logically speaking, this is a divine site where ordinary demons can hardly enter. How could they break into the Chaotic Realm?" Rong Jin, who had injured one leg, also limped toward everyone. "Is it for revenge against the immortal sects?"

"If it were for revenge against the immortal sects, they would just slaughter disciples. Why steal beast stones?" Hong Ying couldn't figure it out.

Ning Fuyi noticed that Chu Qingqiu had not been speaking, but was slightly closing her eyes, as if sensing something.

"These beast stones are just fake and can't be used for cultivation..."

"But they can open Shenyu¹." Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke up, drawing everyone's attention.

Upon hearing this, everyone's expressions changed. Just as they were about to say something, the ground beneath their feet suddenly shook violently, causing people to stagger and scream.

Feng Ge suddenly pointed at the horizon and shouted in terror: "Heaven! Look quickly!"

They saw that the originally azure sky suddenly began burning like ignited rice paper, with roaring flames in all directions - east, south, west, and north. Where the flames had burned, dark colors were revealed, but that darkness was not like night - it was death.

"The Chaotic Realm is collapsing!" Someone screamed at the top of their lungs. At the same time, many voices shouted from the dense forest, obviously disciples from other sects had also discovered this scene and were panicking as they moved toward the center.

As the fire burned more fiercely, the originally lush dense forest also caught fire. The entire Chaotic Realm was rapidly shrinking at a terrifying speed, closing in on everyone as if to devour them all.

The location where Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate stood was the center. They could see dense crowds of disciples running out from all directions, all with panicked expressions.

"Divine Venerable, what should we do!" Hong Ying also lost his usual composure, his voice changing pitch.

"Stop shouting. Those people have already cut off the connection between this place and the outside world. Tell everyone to use immortal power to stop the Chaotic Realm from collapsing." Chu Qingqiu suddenly opened her eyes, her voice calm. She suddenly soared into the air, her garments flowing in the fierce wind like scattered lotus petals.

At the same time, brilliant white light spread out from around her body, illuminating the remaining Chaotic Realm like midday. The previously fierce flames were overshadowed, and the burning speed suddenly slowed.

"It's Chu Ling Divine Venerable!" Someone shouted in the crowded masses. The disciples who had been terrified immediately breathed a sigh of relief, the despair on their faces temporarily disappearing as they obediently summoned their immortal power. Thousands of light beams pierced into the void.

For a moment, there was magnificent immortal power everywhere. Everyone's strength formed a firm barrier, temporarily stopping the Chaotic Realm's destruction.

Ning Fuyi, who was busy picking up something, stood at the back of the crowd and looked up.

Actually, Chu Qingqiu had always been like this - powerful as the sun and moon, revered by all immortal sects, beloved by all living beings in the world.

The people loved her, and she loved universally.

It's just that her gaze would never fall on one person alone. That was all.

Footnotes:

1. **Shenyu (神陨)** - "Divine Meteor" or "Divine Fall," the forbidden sacred area where ancient war gods fell, containing powerful artifacts and treasures